> "WE MUST ACT WITH VINDICTIVE EARNESTNESS AGAINST THE SIOUX, EVEN TO THEIR EXTERMINATION, MEN, WOMEN, AND CHILDREN."
>
> **GENERAL SHERMAN,** 1866



Decorated defence
Shields were very important to the Plains Indians, not only because of the obvious physical protection they provided, but also because of spiritual associations. This hunting shield is painted with a silhouette of a bison and decorated with feathers.

The Indians' traditional key weapon was the composite bow, made of wood backed with sinew. A Sioux warrior was trained in shooting a bow from childhood and could deliver arrows onto a target with speed and accuracy. His other traditional weapons were a long lance and a knife that was used for finishing off the wounded and for scalping. Tomahawks were ceremonial objects rather than weapons of war. The equipment that the Sioux used was constantly evolving, especially under the impact of contact with European settlers and traders. By the second half of the 19th century Sioux were as likely to ride their horses with stirrups and saddle as they were to ride bareback, while their arrows had metal tips, instead of the traditional flint. They also owned large quantities of firearms, including rifles and Colt pistols, either captured or obtained by trade. The Sioux never achieved an effectiveness with firearms to match their skill with the bow.

Although a Plains Indian warrior saw warfare as a chance to prove his individual prowess, he was used to fighting as part of a disciplined group. The discipline was imposed by a number of warrior societies within the tribe.

WARRIOR SOCIETIES

Made up of men who had proved their courage and ability, these societies acted as a kind of police force upholding collective rules against the impulsiveness of unruly individuals. The warrior societies had an especially important task in the hunting season, when success in killing bison was essential to the tribe's survival. They would severely punish any junior warrior who menaced the overall success of the hunt by stepping out of line. This discipline could also be applied to warfare. When the Sioux found themselves engaged in a life-or-death struggle with the US Army and white settlers, the organization and direction provided by the warrior societies was crucial to coping with such an unprecedented challenge.

War between various Sioux nations and the United States was almost inevitable as their territory lay across the path of US westward expansion. From the early 1860s, the Indian peoples responded to aggressive incursions by settlers and the US Army with raids against isolated outposts and settlements, using the hit-and-run tactics familiar from intertribal warfare. Transport and communication links were disrupted, with stagecoaches and supply trains ambushed and telegraph wires ripped down. Travelling faster and lighter than US troops, Sioux warriors could easily evade army columns sent to engage them.

THE BOZEMAN TRAIL

The most successful exercise in Indian guerrilla warfare was led by Chief Red Cloud of the Oglala Sioux in 1866 to 1868. The United States was determined to open up the Bozeman Trail, a route from the East to the Montana gold fields, passing through Sioux hunting grounds. In the summer of 1866 the US Army built three forts along the Trail to give security to travellers. Instead, Sioux attacks on wagon trains increased while the soldiers were trapped inside the forts by warbands that placed them virtually under siege. In December 1866, outside Fort Kearny, Colonel William J Fetterman was lured into pursuit of a temptingly small party of Sioux warriors; they led him into an ambush by a far superior force that massacred Fetterman and the 80 cavalry and infantry with him. Unable to protect travellers, in 1868 the US government agreed to abandon the Bozeman Trail and evacuate the forts. Red Cloud had the distinction of being the only Indian leader to sign a peace treaty as a victor with the United States.



The Sioux's finest hour
Soldiers from General Custer's 7th cavalry make an unsuccessful attempt to resist the charging Plains Indians in June 1876. Although the Sioux are depicted here on horseback it is likely they attacked on foot.